



Evaluation of a Mobile Gratitude Application

Who is conducting the study?

You are invited to participate in this study, “Evaluation of a Mobile Gratitude Application”, that is being conducted by Charlotte Jacques, Dr. Sowmya Somanath, and Dr. Regan Mandryk.

This study will be conducted by Charlotte Jacques, an undergraduate student in the Department of Computer Science at the University of Victoria.

Charlotte can be contacted by telephone at (778) 877-5609 or by e-mail at charlottejacques@uvic.ca

This research is being conducted as part of an Undergraduate Student Research Award (USRA) term under the supervision of Dr. Sowmya Somanath, who can be contacted by phone at (250) 472-5794 or by e-mail at sowmyasomanath@uvic.ca.

What is the purpose of this study?

This study will examine whether providing varying levels of support and guidance through a mobile application is beneficial to users trying to create a regular gratitude practice.

This study is important because it addresses common obstacles people face when trying to establish a gratitude practice. Specifically, it helps people who may struggle to come up with things to be grateful for.

We are studying the effectiveness of this technique among North American adults. You must meet these criteria to participate in this study.

The researchers conducting this study are **not acting as mental health practitioners or providers**. The use of the gratitude app by participants **is not intended to be a clinical psychological intervention**. **This research study is not designed for those who are currently in crisis and/or in need of urgent and/or professional support**. If you identify as needing urgent and/or professional support, please see the resource list [here](#).

It's your choice whether or not you want to take part in this study.
Your participation is voluntary.

If I choose take part in this study, what will I do?

If you take part in this study, you will:

- Complete a short 5-minute demographic questionnaire.
- Complete a happiness assessment both prior to and after completing the study task (detailed below).
- After the completion of the study task, you have the option to sign up for a 30-40 minute interview session with the researcher to reflect on your experience. This interview may be conducted either virtually or in person.

Study Task:

- Over a period of 1 month, you will be able to use the application to log gratitude, through the form of text or image-based logs. The application will send one reminder per day, at either a random or scheduled time, depending on your preference. Specific time windows can also be set.
- The intention of the application is to be used on a daily basis. However, the goal of this study is to observe how users naturally interact with the system, and thus there are no minimum usage requirements.
- The application also contains features providing increased support, as well as a gratitude reflection feature. You are encouraged to use these features if you find yourself in a situation where it may be difficult to think of things to be grateful for.
- One of these support features is a process designed to guide you through reframing your negative emotions. During this process, you will be prompted to log your negative emotions, reflect on any cognitive distortions in your thinking, and complete fill-in-the-blank reframing exercises based on the distortions you selected. Please note that your negative emotion logs may be reviewed for signs of heightened distress among participants (such as mentions of thoughts of harm to self or others, self-destructive behaviours, or current experiences of abuse).
- Another support feature will randomly generate a photo from your camera roll (if you grant the application access to it), and you will be prompted to think of something to be grateful for in this photo. You will be able to select albums that the feature can pull from. Only photos that you choose to add to your gratitude logs will be stored in the database.
- A tutorial video showing how to use the application can be found [here](#). This tutorial is also available through a link in the app after sign-up.

Data will be gathered through the collection of your gratitude logs and reflections, as well as your questionnaire answers and statistics of your usage of the app in general.

Your interview with the researcher, if you choose to participate in one, will also be recorded using either the University of Victoria's Zoom or Microsoft Teams platform. You may choose to turn your camera on or leave it off. The interview is recorded for the purpose of storing your answers only – the footage itself will not be analyzed.

Please be advised that information about you that is gathered for this research study uses Firebase, an online service that stores data in the U.S. As such, there is a possibility that information about you may be accessed without your knowledge or consent by the US government in compliance with the US Freedom Act.

You do not have to answer any questions or complete any tests that make you feel uncomfortable.

How long will this take?

The study will take place over the course of 1 month and will typically require between 5-20 minutes every day.

The pre- and post-assessment happiness questionnaires, as well as the demographic questionnaire, will take approximately 5 minutes each.

Given an estimated average daily time commitment of 10 minutes, you will be required to commit approximately 5 hours and 15 minutes over the entire study period.

All study activities may be completed online or through the application, from any location.

What are the possible harms and discomforts?

If you take part in this study, there is some chance that...

- If you are currently in crisis, the negative emotion logging and reframing process may potentially be triggering or feel like a minimization of your struggles.
- Additionally, through this feature there is a risk of the researchers uncovering serious concerns for your wellbeing or the wellbeing of others around you.
- You may feel vulnerable about logging your gratitude-related entries.

To address these risks, we will take the following steps:

- Firstly, please remember that this study is not intended to be a clinical psychological intervention. If you identify as needing urgent and/or professional support, please do not participate in the study. Instead, we advise you to reach out to a professional or consult the resource list [here](#).
- Every day that you used this app, you will be asked a) that you are still not in a period of crisis, and b) if the app is making you feel additional distress. If you reply “yes” to either of these questions, we will remove you from the study, and ask you to stop using the application. You will be provided with resources and information on how to obtain your compensation.
- If you feel any distress while using the application, you are encouraged to reach out to the researcher at charlottejacques@uvic.ca.
- Before starting the negative emotion logging and reframing process, you will be provided with the following disclaimer:

“Please note that this reframing process is intended for individuals who are experiencing periods of anxiety or low mood primarily caused by unhelpful thinking patterns. These features are not designed for those who are currently in crisis and/or in need of urgent and/or professional support. If you are currently in crisis, please contact emergency services, reach out to a professional, or consult the resources [here](#).”

We ask that you self-assess to determine whether this process will be beneficial to you.

- The aforementioned resources page will be easily accessible throughout the app.
- We will be monitoring the negative emotion logs twice per week for signs of heightened distress (such as mentions of thoughts of harm to self or others, self-destructive behaviours, or current experiences of abuse). If we see such signs, we will reach out to you and provide you with support and resources. In this case, we will unfortunately have to end your participation in the study, and ask that you no longer use the app.
- If you feel vulnerable about your gratitude logs, please know that your input data will not be judged as that is not the goal of our study. We are simply interested in learning about how you think wellbeing tools can or cannot help. Feel free to discuss these concerns in either your intake meeting or final interview, or reach out to the researcher at any point at charlottejacques@uvic.ca.

What are the possible benefits of taking part in this study?

You may benefit from the study through an increased life satisfaction and happiness from the regular gratitude practice that you are prompted to create, both during and after the study if you choose to continue the habit.

Will I receive any compensation for taking part in the study?

If you choose to participate in an interview, you will receive a \$20 CAD Amazon gift card as a small thank-you gift. Otherwise, there will be no compensation.

Who will see my information?

Information collected during this study will be stored and secured using Firebase Realtime Database, and images you log will be kept on Firebase Cloud Storage. Firebase encrypts your data, and is certified under major privacy and security standards, including the ISO 27001 and SOC 1, SOC 2, and SOC3 evaluation processes.

Your data is subject to Firebase’s terms and conditions, and may be accessible by Google, Firebase’s parent company, as necessary to perform their services. Additionally, since Firebase is based in the US, your data may be accessed by the US government in compliance with the US Freedom Act, as discussed above.

Apart from this, only the researchers will have access to your data.

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Your data will be collected under a randomly generated user ID. This user ID is not tied in the system to any of your direct personal identifiers.

After the conclusion of the study, you will be given the option to continue using the application for your own personal benefit. If you choose to do so, your data will be kept indefinitely or until you choose to delete your account. As long as your data is kept, Firebase will still reserve the right to access your data as per their privacy policy. However, any data added after the study period will not be examined by the researcher.

If you choose not to continue using the app, data will be stored on the database for up to a 5 year period. At the end of this time, all database records and interview recordings will be deleted.

How will the study results be shared?

Findings from this study may be reported in journal articles and/or presented at conferences. Your name will not be used in these publications or presentations.

Please note:

If you choose to participate in an interview, you may end it at any time.

You may change your mind and withdraw from this study at any time. There is no need to explain why you have changed your mind. If you would like to withdraw, you can do so through the app's settings page.

If you withdraw from the study your contribution will not be used in the analysis or final report.

At the beginning and end of the study period, including if you meet with the researcher, you will be reminded that your participation in the study is voluntary, and asked if you wish to continue to take part.

If you have any questions or if you would like to discuss this study further, please contact the researcher by telephone at (778) 877-5609 or by e-mail at charlottejacques@uvic.ca.

You can also contact the Human Research Ethics Office at the University of Victoria at 250-472-4545 or ethics@uvic.ca, to check the ethical approval of this study, or to raise any concerns you might have.

Please remember that participation in this study is voluntary.

Consent:

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I have read this consent letter ☐ Yes ☐ No

I have had the opportunity to ask questions ☐ Yes ☐ No

I understand that my participation in this study is voluntary ☐ Yes ☐ No

I understand that I can withdraw my consent at any time ☐ Yes ☐ No

I certify that I reside in North America and am over the age of 19 ☐ Yes ☐ No

I agree to take part in the study ☐ Yes ☐ No

I agree to have my interview recorded, if I choose to take part in one ☐ Yes ☐ No

I agree to have data I entered on the app to be used for research purposes ☐ Yes ☐ No

I understand that this is a research study, and I confirm that I am not currently in crisis and/or in need of urgent and/or professional support ☐ Yes ☐ No

Name of Participant

Email Address

Date

Signature

A copy of this consent form will be automatically emailed to both you and the researcher upon submission.